The STAR Method, Done Properly

A Practical Guide for Behavioral Interviews

Behavioral questions ("Tell me about a time you disagreed with a teammate") trip up more candidates than technical ones, mostly because people either ramble or give answers with no result. The STAR method fixes both problems if you use it with some discipline.

1. **Situation (about 15% of your answer).** One or two sentences of context: the team, the project, the stakes. Skip the company history.
2. **Task (about 10%).** What were you specifically responsible for? Interviewers want to hear your role, not the team's.
3. **Action (about 60%).** This is the heart of the answer. Describe the concrete steps you took, in order, and say "I" rather than "we". Mention one decision you made and why you made it.
4. **Result (about 15%).** Give a measurable outcome if you can (time saved, revenue, bugs reduced, a customer kept) and one sentence on what you learned.

How to prepare without memorizing scripts:

- Write down 6 to 8 stories from your last few roles: a conflict, a failure, a tight deadline, a leadership moment, a time you changed your mind, and a project you are proud of. Most behavioral questions map onto one of these.
- For each story, note the numbers. "Cut onboarding time from two weeks to four days" is far more memorable than "made onboarding faster".
- Practice out loud and time yourself. A good STAR answer runs about 90 seconds to two minutes.
- Prepare a follow-up layer: interviewers often ask "What would you do differently?" Have an honest answer ready.

Common mistakes: spending a minute on the situation, describing what the team did instead of what you did, choosing a "failure" that is really a humblebrag, and ending without a result.

If you want to rehearse with feedback, mock-interview with a friend, record yourself, or use an AI tool for job interviews such as Linkjob AI, which can help you practice structured answers based on your own resume. Disclosure: I work on Linkjob AI.

Good luck, and remember that a clear, specific story beats a polished but vague one every time.